खण्ड–A / Section-A

उम्मीदवारों को इस भाग में लिखना मना है। Candidates must not write on this margin

Q.1 The function of education is to teach one to think intensively and to think critically.
शिक्षा का कार्य व्यक्ति को गहनता और आलोचनात्मक ढंग से सोचना सिखाना है।

Q.2 Life is what happens when you're busy making other plans.
जब आप अन्य योजनाएँ बनाने में व्यस्त होते हैं, तब जो घटित होता है, वही जीवन है।

Q.3 The heaviest penalty for declining to rule is to be ruled by someone inferior.
शासन करने से इनकार करने की सबसे बड़ी सजा किसी निम्नतर व्यक्ति द्वारा शासित होना है।

Q.4 Competition is the law of the jungle, but cooperation is the law of civilization.
प्रतिस्पर्धा, जंगल का कानून है और सहयोग, सभ्यता का कानून है।

Life is what happens when you're busy making other plans

Steven Smith was an aspiring off-spin bowler in the Australian Cricket team. His fondness for off spin bowling was shaped while watching his idol Shane Warne on live TV. He diligently practised : day in and day out and gradually his stats improved, but he was not yet in the contention of becoming a great.

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During a West Indies tour, one of the batsman of the Aussie team fell ill, which gave Smith the opportunity to bat. He went on to score his maiden century and became one of the greatest test batters todays, probably next to legends like Bradman & Tendulkar.

What the above incident shows ~~to~~ us, is actually quite amusing: Life is what happens when we are busy making other plans. It basically highlights the key ingredient of 'Randomness' in our lives. In this essay, we will try to explore more upon the topic and delve into nuances of randomness.

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But before doing so, let us decode as to what exactly we mean by 'Life'? The answer is yet to be satisfactorily and unanimously answered. Right from the Nasadiya Sukta of Rigveda, humans have been intrigued by it.

Even so, thousands of years later, the Greek school which boasted of stalwarts like Socrates, Plato, etc. deeply delved upon this. Probably, the closest which we have come, is by equating life with randomness. But, if that is the case, then the logical question which arises is that why do we humans plan?

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Planning may be accused to various reasons: Firstly, comes the factor of 'uncertainty' and the very 'risk-averse' nature of humans, as was proved by Nobel laureate Daniel Kahneman. like we try to plan our careers from very young ages. Not only individuals, even economies like USSR, India planned their trajectories.

Secondly, we as species are competitive and we try to plan to outcompete others: be at school and getting better marks by planning extended study hours or at corporates and quest to secure better pay.

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Ultimately, planning provides us a clear course of action which reduces our cognitive load as we progress further.

But, despite so much planning, why do things do not go as planned? Why does the randomness kicks-in? There are many factors which go beyond our imagination as well as our control. Take the case of Covid-19 pandemic: where in a microscopic virus put the world to a screeching halt! Even the best planned systems of the world got overwhelmed, let aside the developing nations.

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So, can we then conclude that randomness is inevitable? Well, it doesn't appear to be categorically true all the times. Sometimes, human cognition can surprise us in ways unexpected. Be it the likes of Raghuram Rajan, who could predict the 2008 Global crisis or even the scientists who are campaigning hard to warn us about extreme climatic events of future.

Even before thousands of years, Buddhist philosophy of 'Pratitya Samutpada' rejected randomness and argued that every event can be explained by an underlying cause.

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So, the ultimate bottomline turns out to be that although ~~some~~ most of the events could be linked to an underlying cause, the human intellect is not mature enough yet to pre-empt such events and prevent them.

Another pertinent question is that why does there seems to be a general abhorrance to factor of randomness? Time and again it has been proved that "what doesn't kills us, makes us stronger" i.e. facing unprecedented events strengthens us to face even bigger challenges of future. So, actually we must enjoy the process of unpredictability.

उम्मीदवारों को इस स्तंभ में लिखना मना है। Candidates must not write on this margin

The journey is as important as the destiny. And sometimes, due to random events, it leads to life-long experiences worth ~~cherishing~~ cherishing. The fruits which were offered to Lord Ram by Shabri is the perfect example to cite. The level of love & kindness was unprecedented and definitely boosted Lord Ram's energy.

Now, coming to the billion dollar question: Does the exercize of planning in itself a futile one, if it fails to fully implement itself? Answer seems to be not very affirmative. Planning is not completely useless "Failing to Plan is planning to fail" has been an age old adage.

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Had India not planned its Economy post Independence, we may not be in same situation as we are today. The sheer exploitation of roughly ~ $45 Trn. by colonials had deeply crippled us, which was itself unplanned. But still, we gradually picked our resources & rebuilt slowly but steadily and have today replaced UK to become 4th largest Economy.

The ultimate crux of our discussion simply ponders upon the question of as to how can we reduce the gap of what we plan and what are the ultimate outcomes.

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Firstly, we need to plan better. today's era is witnessing numerous unprecedented challenges. Be it in regards of Climate change or the rising threats from AI. Potential challenges in Present and more so in future are grave and we can't go lethargic in planning for the same. we owe it to ourselves and many of our coming generations, and we need to steadfast to ideal of 'stewardship' by Gandhiji.

Increasing collaboration with different stakeholders in a democratic setup, often leads to refinement of decisions. Just like we are engaging more and

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more Environmental scientists in our Climate Change planning, in the same manner, we must incorporate grassroot leaders like Tulsi Gowda Ji, who recently was bestowed by Padma Award for her life long committment to Envt. conservation.

The stage after planning is of implementation, monitoring and feedback which should be continuously fed in a loop-like manner to rectify our errors in initial thesis/planning.

By these small improvements, we can certainly improve (if not eliminate) the gap between plan and outcome.

अभ्यर्थियों को इस मार्जिन में लिखना मना है। Candidates must not write on this margin

Ultimately, we should focus on the process and care least about the results. Bhagwat Geeta says:

"You only have a right to do your duties, let the work of rewarding be bestowed upon almighty."

An even better scenario would be to live by the precious saying of 'AMOR FATI': the love of fate: "whatever happens, happens for our good, and we may not realize this initially, but sometimes later, albeit gradually."